

THE MISSING DOCTOR

Watson did not disappear by accident. He answered messages, returned calls, and left notes whenever danger drew him away.

When his phone fell silent, Holmes called it strange. By morning, no patient, message, or witness could explain the absence. **John Watson was officially missing.**



Lestrade searched hospitals, cameras, stations, river paths, and Watson's last appointments. London offered movement everywhere and certainty nowhere.

Watson had been listening to frightened people who trusted neither police nor press. Their secrets had become his final case, and perhaps the reason he vanished.



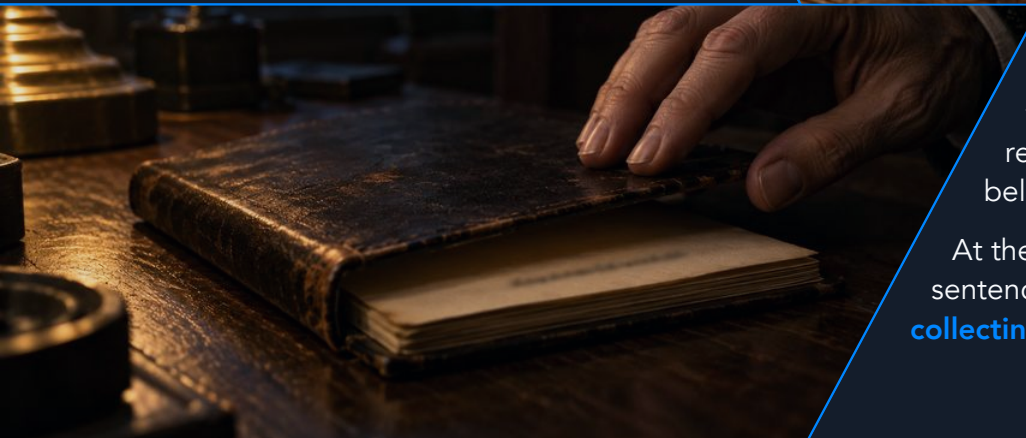
Watson's file named three strangers: Martin Vale, Miriam Cross, and Peter Rance. Each paid, panicked, then disappeared or died.

Their lives never crossed, yet the sequence was identical. The payments looked voluntary. **The fear surrounding them did not.**



Money moved first. Then came fear, followed by silence. Watson had recognized the order before anyone believed there was an order at all.

At the top of his notebook he left one sentence. Holmes read it once: **Someone is collecting sins.**



THE SWITCH

Lestrade searched before London fully woke. Mycroft opened doors beyond ordinary police reach. Holmes arrived from Sussex carrying only Watson's notebook.

Retirement had taught him patience with bees, but not with Watson's absence. His expression belonged to older wars.



Mycroft's official timeline was neat, careful, and nearly useless. Holmes studied its empty spaces instead of its entries.

Three hours later, an email arrived from Watson. Its subject read *If I miss the window*. No one spoke while the encrypted attachment downloaded.

Watson had built a dead-man switch and delayed it every twenty-four hours. Missing the window released an encrypted archive to Holmes and Mycroft.

The message said only that he could no longer act. Inside waited interviews, wallet addresses, photographs, and names crossed out in black.



Across the blackmail files Watson had written one private label: **MILVERTON**. Holmes understood. Charles Augustus Milverton had once made an industry from shame.

The machinery had changed. The business had not. Around it stood a fence built from money, fear, and silence.

THE LEDGER

The payments followed a pattern Watson had noticed but never proved. Each victim had trusted the same polished settlement process before fear closed around them.

A survivor supplied the next lead: the computer used during payment. Lestrade recovered it before anyone could alter what remained.



The settlement client looked ordinary and had completed the task its owner expected. Holmes was interested in what happened beyond the screen.

The machine was sealed for examination. Investigators had to establish what the client had really done and whether it could lead them deeper into the operation.



POST-SOLVE CONTENT HIDDEN
REVEAL AFTER SHERLOCK

